

portraits of the greats. In his portraits of Bismillah Khan, Bhimsen Joshi and Mallikarjun Mansur, his subjects' heads are often tilted upward, expressing fully submerged devotion. What is more remarkable is that even the visible surroundings, the mundane everyday elements, are composed like musical notes. These are images where Rai is not just recording devotion, but receiving it too.

What distinguishes Rai is a compositional quality that is simultaneously graphic and lyrical. His images of workers in settings of industrial grit and strain show their bodies in languid grace. Even in his political portraits—most memorably of Indira Gandhi—the visual hooks were of soft body language: the saree *pallu* pulled to signify power, hands extending in a *mudra* to suggest her humanity. In the haunting glass eyes of the half-buried child, the palpable human pain of the Bhopal gas tragedy is distilled by the hand caressing its forehead. This deliberate insistence on detail—the small human gesture that carries the weight of the epochal event, is the essential element of the Raghu Rai image.

His essential humanity runs through his frames, almost like a philosophical credo. He instinctively understood that the decisive emphasis does not reside in the momentous or the monumental alone. It is also found in more humble quarters—in the unshed tears of a refugee woman; in the hands of the old man at the ghat; in the child's eye catching the light at the edge of a slum. Rai placed common folk—the undecorated and the perpetually overlooked—at the nerve centre of the nation's memory of itself. In his image-world, the ordinary was never a backdrop. It was the protagonist.

HIS CREDO: NEVER EXCLUDE

This philosophical positioning found its most unexpected expression in his use of the panoramic camera for street photography. Where most photographers reach for the panoramic medium to capture landscape and spectacle, Rai turned it inward. The elongated frame in his hands became a way of holding a street corner and its inhabitants in a single, unbroken breath, without hierarchy. It gave him the democracy he was always seeking: no subject pressed to the edge, everyone held within the same unhurried attention. It was a technical paradox that only makes sense once you understand his deepest instinct, which was never to exclude.

That credo permeated everything that Rai did—through the 1971 photographs that gave the Bangladesh refugee crisis its human face, through the Taj Mahal series that returned that exhausted monument to mystery, through the decades of portraiture in which political leaders and street folk were accorded the same unbiased eye. When he photographed mourners at a Banaras ghat, the workers of Chawri Bazaar in Delhi, or followed Mother Teresa through the lanes of Calcutta, he seemed to be threading each visual into a sacred sutra, one that united all souls in a karmic destiny towards the infinite.

The visual metaphor, therefore, that naturally comes to mind for Raghu Rai's lifework is that of a rosary—each photograph a bead, strung together unbroken, burnished smooth by the millions of eyes that have seen them. And threading it, a vision of India that was never ideological, never touristy, never propagandist—but always, always human.

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He was a looming presence in the cultural life of Delhi—large in frame and in laughter, exacting in his standards, generous with the young who came seeking guidance. Three generations of Indian photographers carry his eye, his seeing in their own, whether they know it or not. In the way they hold the light. The way they resist the easy image. The way they wait. What Raghu Rai leaves behind is not merely a body of work. It is a visual memory of India—its grief and grace, its sacred and scars, its maharajas and migrants, its silence and clamour—all held imperishably within the amber of the photographic frame. The rosary has slipped from the hand that strung it. But the beads remain, each one—luminous, warm, asking us to look... really look... at this country we inhabit and so rarely see.

The eye closes. The images endure. ■